

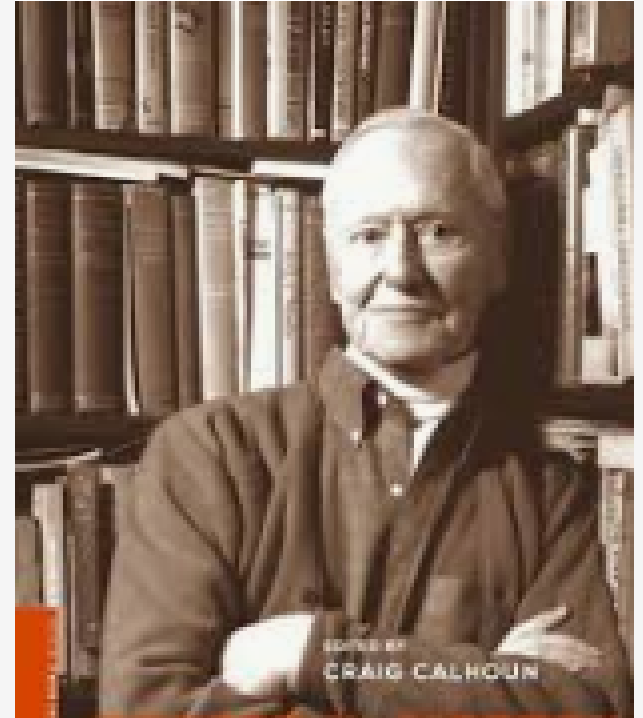


ROBERT MERTON: STRAIN THEORY

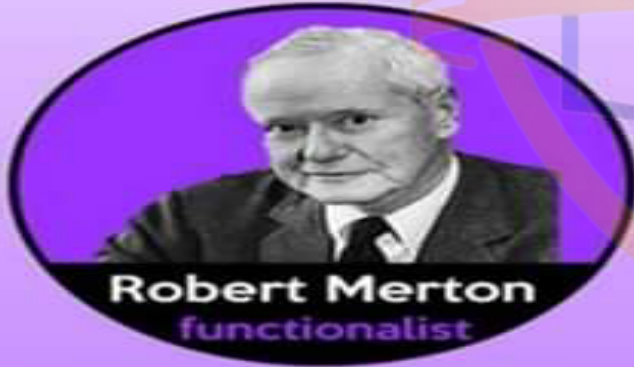
Miss Uswah Liaqat

Robert Merton: Strain Theory

- Merton defined five ways that people respond to gap between having a socially accepted goal but no socially accepted way to pursue it.



merton's strain theory



Robert Merton
functionalist

There is a link between high crime rates and **anomie**

Anomie means a state of normlessness in society

Merton suggests **anomie** is created through **strain**. **Strain** is the gap between an individual's goals in life (e.g. getting rich), and their ability of achieving these.

Ability to achieve goals

← strain →

Your goals in life

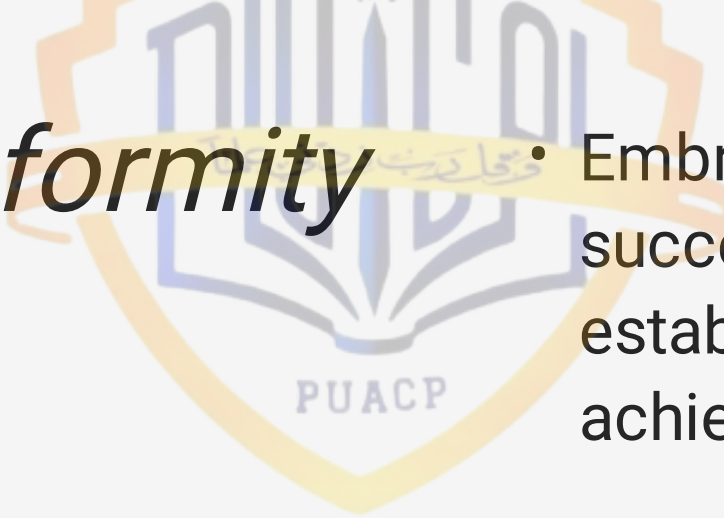
5 ways people react to this **strain**
– 3 of which can be criminal...

Conformity, Ritualism, Innovation, Retreatism, Rebellion

ONE OF EASIEST DIAGRAM FOR UNDERSTANDING MERTON'S THEORY

5 RESPONSES	GOALS		MEANS	
Conformity	LEGAL GOALS	+	LEGAL MEANS	+
Innovation	LEGAL GOALS	+	ILLIGEAL MEANS	-
Ritualism	NO GOALS	-	LEGAL MEANS	+
Retreatism	ILLEGAL GOALS	-	ILLIGEAL MEANS	-
Rebellion	ILLEGAL GOALS	-	ILLIGEAL MEANS	-
	↓		↓	
	LEGAL GOALS	+	LEGAL MEANS	+

Conformity

A large, faint watermark of the PUACP logo is visible in the background. It features a shield-like shape with a yellow border, containing a blue stylized book and the acronym 'PUACP' in blue letters.

- Embracing the society's definition of success and adhering to the established and approved means of achieving success.
 - Those who conform choose not to deviate. They pursue their goals to the extent that they can through socially accepted means.
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	↓		↓	
	LEGAL GOALS	+	LEGAL MEANS	+

The logo of the Punjab University of Architecture, Civil and Planning (PUACP) is visible in the background. It features a shield-like emblem with a stylized open book and a quill pen, surrounded by Arabic calligraphy. The acronym 'PUACP' is written below the emblem.

Innovation

- Use of illicit means to reach approved goals.
 - Those who innovate pursue goals they cannot reach through legitimate means by instead using criminal or deviant means.
-

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The logo of the Philippine University of Arab College of Psychology (PUACP) is located in the upper left background. It features a shield with a yellow border, containing a blue open book and a yellow quill pen. The acronym 'PUACP' is written in blue below the book.

Ritualism

- People who ritualize lower their goals until they can reach them through socially acceptable ways. These members of society focus on conformity rather than attaining a distant dream.
 - Using the same socially approved means to achieve less elusive goals.
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	↓		↓	
	LEGAL GOALS	+	LEGAL MEANS	+

The logo of the Punjab University of Architecture, Civil and Planning (PUACP) is located in the upper left background. It features a shield-like emblem with a stylized open book in the center, topped with a quill pen. The acronym 'PUACP' is written in blue capital letters below the book. The entire emblem is encircled by a yellow ring with a gear-like outer edge.

Retreatism

- To reject both the cultural goals and the means to obtain it, then find a way to escape it.
 - Others retreat and reject society's goals and means.
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- A solid black circle is positioned in the bottom right corner of the slide.

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Rebellion

- Rejecting the socially approved ideas of "success" and the means of attaining that of "success, but replaces those with alternative definitions of success and alternative strategies for attaining the new goals.
- A handful of people rebel, replacing a society's goals and means with their own. Terrorists or freedom fighters look to overthrow a society's goals through socially unacceptable means.
- To reject the cultural goals and means, then work to replace them.

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merton's 5 reactions to strain

Conformity

People continue to try and achieve their goals through legitimate means, through conforming to society's norms and values, e.g. working hard to get a promotion at work

Ritualism

People give up on their goals, but still continue to go through the motions of life, in a ritual like fashion, e.g. just turning up to work everyday

Innovation

People realise they will not achieve their goals through legitimate means, so innovate their means (often criminally) to achieve them. E.g. robbing a bank, rather than working in one

Retreatism

People give up on their goals, reject any means to reach them and so retreat from mainstream society. E.g. dropping out of work and becoming a drug addict

Rebellion

People reject society's goals and the means of achieving them, so rebel against society. E.g. dropping out of work to engage in terrorist activity